Neighborhood Moves Have Age-Dependent Later Effects

Moving to a lower-poverty neighborhood before adolescence increased later college attendance and adult earnings in Moving to Opportunity; this is an adult-economic finding, not a toddler-development law, and moving is not universally beneficial.

TER-EARNINGS; LOW-TO-MODERATE-EARLY-DEV; LOW-EVERY-CHARACTERISTIC | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: ECOLOGY, POLICY | R

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Housing is a bundle: stability, crowding, affordability, safety, toxins, mobility, and neighborhood opportunity. Chetty, Hendren & Katz (2016) reanalyzed Moving to Opportunity: children who moved to lower-poverty neighborhoods before age 13 had higher later college attendance and adult earnings; moves in adolescence produced smaller or slightly negative effects, plausibly reflecting disruption. Earlier MTO reports found few detectable effects on contemporaneous achievement—near-term developmental scores and long-run economic outcomes can diverge.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

MTO is a randomized voucher experiment. Effects belong to the intervention package and context, not to a broad “neighborhood quality” construct. BEIP (severe-institutional-deprivation.md) is severe deprivation, not ordinary housing mobility. Childcare quality is a different exposure.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

The headline MTO estimate for young movers is about 35% higher individual earnings in adulthood—not a toddler test-score effect. Persistence here is life-course economic, not an infant cognition claim.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (randomized housing voucher experiment, not an observational parenting phenotype).

Age at move, disruption, take-up, school and peer environments, and pollution all matter. Neighborhood effects in the broader observational literature are typically modest.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Moving is not universally beneficial. Place does not determine destiny. Families cannot individually solve hazardous housing and segregation. A later earnings gain is not proof that toddlers in higher-poverty neighborhoods lack parental care.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Prioritize stable, affordable, healthy housing and hazard reduction. Evaluate mobility policies for both benefits and disruption, by child age and domain.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Chetty, Hendren & Katz (2016), American Economic Review